Improving Bloomberg Terminal Access with Claude CoWork

Executive Summary

Bloomberg Terminal is an important tool for Georgia Tech students. It gives them access to financial data and analytics tools necessary for academic and professional success (Georgia Institute of Technology Library). But its complicated and command-based interface makes it harder for new users (students) who haven't used something similar before. Current onboarding relies on informal word-of-mouth and scattered resources, so learning experiences are inconsistent and inefficient.

This report examines key challenges associated with using Bloomberg Terminal, including its steep learning curve, command-based interface, and lack of structured onboarding, and suggests developing structured training materials. These materials include both step-by-step guides and AI-based workflows like using Anthropic's Claude CoWork to help users get the most out of the Terminal.

The suggested solution seeks to enhance accessibility and optimize workflow efficiency for novice users. It's important to note that whilst the report is best served towards fintech and business communities, the training materials are applicable to all Georgia Tech students (as all students have access to Bloomberg Terminal). These training materials will help students learn how to use Bloomberg Terminal faster and better by combining clear instructional design with an AI-assisted interpretation. It should offer a long-term way to onboard Georgia Tech's "financial-minded" community..

Assessing Technical Communication Needs

Bloomberg Terminal is a popular tool used in Georgia Tech's fintech and business communities for financial analysis, market research, and making decisions based on data. The platform is widely used as an industry-standard tool in finance, but it has a steep learning curve. Most of the command arguments are proprietary and its interface provides a lot of information to process.

At the moment, onboarding for Bloomberg is informal and not centralized. There are some official Bloomberg resources, such as *Getting Started Guide for Students* and university library guides from institutions like NYU and Montclair State, but they are not tailored to students nor Georgia Tech's student community and often assume prior experience with the platform (Bloomberg L.P.; New York University Libraries; Montclair State University Library). At Georgia Tech, most students don't realize we have access to the Terminal in our libraries, and those that do will just explore on their own or use word-of-mouth.

There are a few big problems with this process. First, the command-based navigation system makes users remember certain functions, which is difficult if they don't understand the context. Second, there is so much data and so many features that it can be hard to find the right tools for the job. Third, absent a clear workflow, the user would have to piece together specific actions to do something basic like analyze a stock.

There is also a lack of information on how modern tools like large language models can support Bloomberg Terminal usage in practice. For example, students could use external LLM tools alongside the Terminal to translate natural language questions into specific Bloomberg commands, interpret complex outputs, and receive step-by-step guidance for completing tasks such as stock analysis or market research. LLMs provide an abstraction that simplifies the command-based interface by turning complex inputs into accessible language, while also suggesting relevant workflows and next steps (Joyce).

These gaps show that training materials need to be more organized, easy to find, and focused for the community. In this case, good technical communication should focus on being clear and available whilst addressing problems the new users have.

Recommendations

From the analysis of the existing communication situation, there are gaps with the technical communication regarding the resources from Bloomberg Terminal as to how well Georgia Tech students interact with these resources. Some of the gaps are a lack of a centralized training programing, constant exposure to the Terminal and awareness about the resource. Our research into technical communication showed that users learn systems efficiently when information is organized into structured, task-based guidance (Joyce 2019). As such, there are three recommendations that should be made regarding Georgia Tech's communication to its students.

The first and most immediate recommendation is to maintain a Bloomberg terminal Planning Guide for Tech students. Although there are various resources available for students, they are decentralized and lack a coherent framework needed for a deeper learning process. The Bloomberg Terminal Guide would act as a central hub for all introductory information pertaining to the terminal.

The Planning Guide would contain instructions on introducing and onboarding students to Bloomberg Terminal. It contains step-by-step workflows and guidelines on how to perform functions like company search & valuation, financial analysis and retrieving market data. In addition, plain language explanations would help students grasp what they are doing and why they do it. Finally, being able to explain how those same workflows can be done with Claude adds an extra element for students to see how LLM's can massively increase the efficiency of their day-to-day tasks. As such, providing step-by-step workflows aligns with best practices for learnability, aiming for clarity and progressive guidance (Nielsen Norman Group).

The second recommendation would be to embed Bloomberg Terminal's instruction in Georgia Tech courses that related to finance, securities & investments, or even accounting (still applicable with the financial statements of companies that the Terminal grants access to). Right now, the main demographic of students that know about Bloomberg Terminal is within the GTSF Investments Committee, a student-run club on campus. Because access to the Terminal is restricted to designated workstations, incorporating it into coursework would maximize the scope of students reached, and more Tech students could learn in an organized and consistent manner (Georgia Tech Library). This is especially important given that Bloomberg Terminal is the industry-standard platform in finance, and effectively using it requires structured training (Bloomberg L.P.).

Thirdly, there is a need for improved communication regarding the importance of Bloomberg Terminal. Most students won't know about the access to this software, especially since it's accessible in the Price Gilbert Library and requires advance reservation (Georgia Tech Library). Improving communication through university libraries or reaching directly to student emails would go a long way in helping students understand Bloomberg Terminal's functionalities and relevance. Increasing awareness is critical because access alone does not ensure usage, particularly for complex platforms like Bloomberg Terminal that require visibility to engage new users (Bloomberg L.P.).

Goals & Audience of Training Materials

This tutorial is designed for introductory training of Georgia Tech students, enrolled in various fintech, business and finance related courses and programs. It is intended for students who are required to use Bloomberg Terminal for academic and professional purposes in finance. In addition, this tutorial will be beneficial to various student organizations focused on finance.

Training resources for this target audience will presuppose a strong understanding of financial concepts, but lack proficiency with tools such as Bloomberg Terminal and other programs. This means that some students will have used some of these tools previously, while others will be walking into the classroom cold. As a result, training content and materials will need to be written with the understanding that there will be a mixed level of experience in the classroom. As always, simple and intuitive training resources are key.

Our set of learning resources is designed to significantly reduce the amount of time it takes for new users to get grips with using the Bloomberg Terminal. Whether you are new to Bloomberg or new to finance-related coursework or internships, these resources will guide you through the basics of Terminal navigation, key shortcuts and the financial analyses that you will regularly require. They will help to increase your proficiency and confidence when using the Terminal.

In addition to covering the basics of AI, those training materials will cover how to integrate AI powered workflows and gain insights into your data. We will introduce users to AI tools such as Claude and teach how to apply these tools in order to maximize learning. For example, students can use AI tools to ask questions about Bloomberg functions in plain language, receive simplified explanations of outputs, and get step by step guidance when completing tasks, helping them develop more effective workflows and problem-solving techniques (Joyce).

Rationale for Writing & Design Choices

Best practices for technical writing informed our design approach for the training materials. We created a clear and usable design to make materials accessible. A multimodal approach was taken in order to reach different learning styles and engage the user. Written tutorials with examples and video walk-thoughs for users to complete themselves supported the independent use of materials. Screenshots throughout the tutorials were annotated in order to guide the user through specific steps and procedures.

The information on the website has been organized and page layout made clear and consistent. Whenever possible we have outlined instructions on how to carry out the more complex tasks step-by-step.

Making the system accessible is a key aspect of design. Using plain language in instructions for users who are not familiar with your system ensures that those who have limited ability are able to complete actions successfully. Making use of visual cues such as color and size to draw attention to critical elements of and interactions with the interface helps individuals with differing abilities to understand usage (New York Univeristy Libraries).

The new materials don't replace traditional learning with static tutorials powered by AI, instead the new content incorporates elements of AI to better support the learning needs of users. The workflows and other interactive content within the Claude platform are designed to support as much hands-on practice as possible on the Bloomberg Terminal, while also teaching how to utilize AI to help achieve better outcomes.

All the materials were designed with sustainability in mind through a modular Notion-based structure, where content is organized into topic-based pages and lessons that can be easily updated, expanded, and reused. Features such as step-by-step guides, embedded media, and structured modules allow the system to grow over time without requiring major redesign. This approach supports long-term adaptability as Bloomberg Terminal features and student learning needs continue to evolve.

Works Cited

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